

Plenty to ponder before the final push

As Formula One's summer break ends, several **sub-plots** are set to keep fans hooked through the final half of the season.

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The 2025 Formula One season saw 14 action-packed races leading into a well-deserved four-week summer break — the perfect reset for drivers and teams before the final 10 rounds of high-octane action.

As the second half fast approaches, there will be plenty to look forward to — from an intra-team championship fight and a midfield tussle, to looming questions over driver futures and much more.

McLaren's two-horse race

McLaren's revival has been steadily building for years, and last season it finally bore fruit with a long-awaited constructors' championship. Now, the focus shifts to the drivers' crown, a title the team has not claimed since Lewis Hamilton's triumph in 2008. That pursuit, however, brings its own dilemma: both its drivers, Lando Norris (front) and Oscar Piastri (back), are in a fierce duel for the crown.

Norris, the team's homegrown star, has come through ironing out past inconsistencies to keep himself within range of his teammate and rival. The Australian, who holds the championship lead, has showcased his prowess and a rare level of precision. Their battle reflects McLaren's dominance but also poses the classic test of intra-team rivalry: how to let both drivers flourish without fracturing unity. The question may shift from whether the team can deliver a champion to which of its two young stars will seize the moment.



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Red Bull beyond Max Verstappen

Max Verstappen will remain in the Red Bull garage for 2026 — but for how much longer? The Milton Keynes-based outfit has already endured a wave of departures, including design mastermind Adrian Newey and long-serving team principal Christian Horner, among others. The reshuffle marks a new era for the team, yet it is the near future that raises the most pressing questions.

On track, reliability has been a persistent obstacle, undermining Verstappen's bid for a fifth successive title. He has produced two extraordinary victories, but the reigning champion has fallen adrift of the McLaren pair. Compounding matters, Yuki Tsunoda has yet to make a convincing case for promotion, leaving Red Bull without an able partner for Verstappen — let alone a clear successor. The Japanese driver will need to maximise his last 10 races to keep his seat safe. But the absence of a leader could become the team's greatest challenge.



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